C1 Writing

Writing a formal report

Headings, impersonal language and recommendations for workplace and exam reports.

A report presents facts and recommendations to a specific reader, such as a manager or committee. It is clearly organised with headings and uses an impersonal, objective tone.

Typical structure

Heading	Purpose
Introduction	State the aim of the report and how information was gathered.
Findings (two or three headed sections)	Present the facts, grouped by topic.
Recommendations	Suggest specific actions based on the findings.
Conclusion	Summarise briefly, optionally with a final recommendation.

Impersonal language

Personal	Impersonal
We asked 50 staff.	*Fifty staff members were surveyed.*
Most people said they liked it.	*The majority of respondents expressed satisfaction.*
I think we should change the hours.	*It is recommended that the opening hours be extended.*

Useful phrases. *The aim of this report is to... / It was found that... / A significant number of... / It would be advisable to...*

Practice

1. Make impersonal: We found that the canteen is too small.
2. Make impersonal: Lots of people complained about the noise.
3. Make more formal: You should buy new computers.

▼ **Show answers**

1. It was found that the canteen is too small.
2. A significant number of respondents complained about the noise.
3. It is recommended that new computers be purchased.